

Synthetic Media and Truth



BIG IDEA Images, voices and videos can now be made or altered by AI. “Looks real” proves nothing, and “can’t prove it’s fake” proves nothing either. The habit that works is verifying the source and ignoring the glitches.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R6 Claim Cards (nine fictional media claims described in words) per group of 3 to 4, Workbook W6, the four moves on the board: Pause, Source, Second source, Trace. Show no real people, student photos or AI tools.

- ☐ Print the nine Claim Cards. V7 is a voice-cloned family call and V8 a sexual fake of a classmate; handle V8 with care.
- ☐ Write the four moves on the board.
- ☐ Have the Lesson 5 Response Drill in mind.

1 HOOK 2 MIN 60-second script Say: “Last night someone sent you a voice message that sounds exactly like your cousin. They are in trouble and need money. Or a video of a famous person endorsing a giveaway. Two years ago, ‘look for the weird hands’ was decent advice. Now it is bad advice. The glitches are going away, and detectors are unreliable. So the new skill is to verify the source. Today you practice four moves that work whether the fake is good or terrible. And hold on to a second idea: when we cannot prove something is fake, that does not make it real. We will practice sitting in ‘I do not know yet.’”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN Verify Lab

- 1 (1 min) The four moves. Pause** (strong emotion is a signal). **Source:** who posted it first? **Second source:** does an independent, reliable source confirm it? **Trace:** can I find the original? Harmful or false and spreading: report it in the app and tell an adult.
- 2 (4 min) Sort the claims.** For each Claim Card decide: the first move, what good evidence would be, your confidence (Probably real, Probably fake, Do not know yet), and the action (share, do not share, report, tell).
- 3 (2 min) Special cards V7 and V8.** If media shows someone sexualized or humiliated, it is harmful whether or not it is real. Do not forward it, and do not investigate by passing it to friends. Use the Response Drill: Stop, Save details (never the image), Tell, Report. For a voice or video emergency, call back on a number you already have or use your family code word.
- 4 (1 min) Say what you know.** One group: “We said ‘do not know yet’ about ___, and that was right because ___.”

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Which is more dangerous: a fake that fools people, or a real thing people claim is fake?”
- 2** “If AI detectors are unreliable, what else can you rely on?”
- 3** “Why does a fake that makes you angry spread faster? What could slow you down?”

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause on emotion. Check the source and a second source. Tell a trusted adult, and report, when a fake is meant to hurt a person. Add to your Defense Plan: ‘My verification habit is ____, and my family code word or callback rule is ____.’”

Hand signal: Hackles up? A strong reaction to a clip is a trigger to verify (hand brushed up the neck, optional). Post it: “Verify the source, not the pixels.”

EXIT TICKET “A friend sends you a shocking clip. Write the first two things you do before reacting or sharing.”

FUN BOOST Verify Relay. Groups earn points for the best first move per Claim Card, never for speed or a fast verdict. The class may challenge one card per round.

LEVEL-UP Liar’s Dividend Explainer. In two paragraphs, explain why a real recording can be dismissed as fake and what provenance tools can and cannot do.

DIFFERENTIATE Give each claim a traffic-light card (green: confirm quickly; yellow: need a second source; red: harmful, do not share) and the starter “The first thing I would check is ___ because ___.”

FAMILY CARD Choose a family code word and a call-back rule: if someone asks for urgent money or a code, hang up and call back on a number you already have. Ask: “What would you do if you saw a fake of someone you know?”

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “Why did you send it?” or “How could you...?”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”
- “Let me see.” Never view, copy or forward an image.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.